Fools
By Neil Simon

LEON: **(Pg 9-11)** Kulyenchikov, I like it! A quiet, pleasant village. The perfect place for a new schoolteacher to begin his first bona-fide, appointment as a schoolmaster. My heart is pounding with excitement. I don't see anyone around. *(looks at watch)* **(Pg 46)** Nine o'clock. Maybe I arrived a little early. *(Snetsky the shepherd enters)*

SNETSKY: Elenya! Lebidoff! Marushka! Olga! Good morning. Did you happen to see two dozen sheep?

LEON: Two dozen sheep?

SNETSKY: Yes. There were fourteen of them. *(He continues looking)*

LEON: No, I'm sorry.

SNETSKY: Well, if you see them, would you give them a message?

LEON: A message for the sheep?

SNETSKY: Tell them the shepherd is looking for them and they should tell you where they are and I'll come and get them.

LEON: I am Leon Steponovitch Tolchinsky, the new schoolteacher. I was hired by Dr. Zubritsky to teach his young daughter. I am, if I may say so, an excellent teacher.

SNETSKY: Oh, they all were, but not one of them lasted through the first night. We're unteachable. We're all stupid in Kulyenchikov. There isn't a town or village more stupid in all of Mother Poland.

LEON: Russia. Are you telling me that every man, woman, and child -

SNETSKY: All stupid.

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INTRODUCTION

The people of Kulyenchikov are not exactly what Leon Tolchinsky had in mind when he comes to the village. He meets townspeople who seem to not have all of their marbles. He meets a father and energetic wife who want to find someone who can finally teach their daughter Sophia and break the curse that has plagued the village. Leon is running against time to break the curse before he becomes a fool himself in Fools by Neil Simon.

LEON: **(Pg 11)** *(To the audience)* Something is up here! I'm sure Dr. Zubritsky will explain it all to me. *(to Snetsky)* A pleasure meeting you, Citizen Snetsky. *(Scene Change - Leon knocks on door)*

LENYA: **(Pg 16-18)** Nikolai! Nikolai! He's here. Maybe he'll be the one. Maybe this one will finally be our salvation.

DR. Z: Calm yourself, Lenya. Who's come? Who'll be our salvation?

LENYA: The new - er- the new - what do you call them? They come and -er- we had one once but no more.

DR. Z: Oh, I know who you mean. They point to you and they say -er- they ask you -er-... *(Leon knocks)* A knock? Open the knock. *(Lenya opens the door after a struggle with pulling or pushing it open)*

LENYA: Won't you come in?

LEON: Dr. Zubritsky? Madame Zubritsky? I am Leon Steponovitch Tolchinsky.

DR. Z: So you are the new - the new –

LENYA: But you look so young to be a - to be a -

LEON: Not at all. I think you will find that I am, if I may say so, one of the best young teacher(s) in all of Russia!

DR.Z: *(excited)* A teacher! He's a teacher!

LENYA: Perhaps you would like to start teaching right away, teacher?

LEON: Well, no one's more eager than I am. **(Pg 24-26)** We must begin at once. Can I see Sophia?

LENYA: Not from here. She's up in her room. *(Lenya exits to get Sophia)*

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DR. Z: You'll find her a most sensitive girl. She likes to do interesting things… like touching things - wood, paper, metal. She likes drinking water. *(Lenya and Sophia enter)*

LENYA: May I present our daughter - *(looks at a piece of paper in her hand to remind her of Sophia's name)* Sophia Irena Elynya Zubritsky. Sophia, this is Leon Tolchinsky.

LEON: *(aside)* Is that my breath that has just been taken away? *(to Sophia)* Miss Zubritsky - may I call you Sophia?

SOPHIA: Sophia?

DR. Z: It's your name, sweetheart.

SOPHIA: I would be very pleased to have you call me Sophia.

DR. Z: **(Pg 18-23)** *(To Leon)* How can we help you?

LEON: Well, there are a few questions I wanted to ask you first.

DR. Z: Questions! That's what they ask when they point to you!

LENYA: Would you be so kind, Master Tolchinsky, to - ask us a question?

DR. Z: It's been so long since anyone has asked a good "school question."

LEON: Very well… What is the purpose of man's existence?

DR. Z: What a question . . . Lenya, did you ever hear such a beautiful question?

LENYA: I'm speechless . . . To think someone would ask ***us*** a question like that.

LEON: Are you interested in the answer?

DR. Z: Not today, thank you. To be asked one question like that in a lifetime is more than we ever expected. The answer should be given to someone much more worthy than we are.

LEON: But knowledge is ***everyone's*** birthright.

DR. Z: Everyone not born in Kylyenchikov.

LEON: I don't understand.

LENYA: You would if you knew about the nurse.

LEON: What nurse?

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DR. Z: Not the nurse, the purse.

LEON: What kind of purse?

DR. Z: The kind of purse that inflicts wrath upon all the poor souls unfortunate enough to be born in this village.

LEON: Do you mean, perhaps, a curse?

DR. Z: Curse! I ***knew*** it sounded like that.

LENYA: We were so close! ***So*** close!

LEON: What is this curse you speak of?

DR. Z: Lenya, bolt the door. Draw the curtains.

LENYA: I can't draw curtains. I can draw a cat or a fish -

DR. Z: Never mind. Lower your voice.

LENYA: *(bends knees)* How low do you want my voice?

DR. Z: That's low enough. Young man, have you ever heard of the Curse of Kulyenchikov?

LEON: I can't say that I have.

DR. Z: You can't say that? It's not hard. Even Lenya can say that.

LENYA: "The Curse of Kyluenchikov!"

LEON: Doctor, I don't believe in curses. Curses are old wives' tales.

DR. Z: You're thinking of Noychka. In Noychka, all the old wives have tails.

LEON: But where did the curse come from?

DR. Z: [It happened] two hundred years ago. It's all documented in ***The Book of Curses***. Here. *(hands book to him)* Read it yourself. The page is marked.

LEON: *(Attempting to open the book)* It's all stuck together.

LENYA: We marked it with maple syrup. Read it to us!

LEON: *(Reading)* "In the year 1691, in the village of Kulyenchikov, a young, handsome but illiterate farmer name Casimir Yousekevitch fell in love with the daughter of the most learned man in the town Mickhail Zubritsky."

LENYA: Zubritsky! I've heard that name before!

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DR. Z: I've seen it! On a front door somewhere. In this neighborhood.

LEON: It's on your front door. ***Your*** name is Zubritsky.

DR. Z: *(With profound insight)* Wait a minute! That means that the young man in the curse may possibly be related - to our front door.

LEON: "The young girl's name was Sophia Zubritsky." Sophia? Your daughter [has] the identical name of the girl in the curse over two hundred years ago.

DR. Z: I can't believe it. Unless she has been lying about her age.

LEON: "The match was doomed. When Sophia's educated father learned that young Casimir was illiterate, he forbade Sophia to ever see [him] again. That winter Casimir took his life by plowing his own grave and planting himself in it. Upon hearing of his son's death, Casimir's father, Vladimir Yousekvitch, brought all his wrath and fury down upon Kulyenchikov. *(quoting Yousekvitch)* A curse! May the daughter of Mikahil Zubritsky, murderer of my only son, be struck down by the ignorance that caused my son's death! May her children [and] all who live in Kulyenchikov be cursed with ignorance and stupidity for all eternity, unable to leave this cursed village until my final vengeance has been satisfied!"

LENYA: That would explain why the train doesn't stop here.

LEON: *(aside)* My initial impulse was to panic. To educate is one thing - to break curses is another.

DR. Z: Excuse me, but are you alright?

LEON: Yes. I was just thinking.

DR. Z: Lenya… he was thinking.

LENYA: He was thinking.

DR. Z: What's it like?

LEON: You mean you don't know what thinking is?

DR. Z: I don't and she certainly doesn't.

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LEON: **(Pg 24)** Patience! We will break this curse, I promise you! By the simple, everyday, painstaking work of education.

DR. Z: Would I be able to open up jars? I have a terrible trouble opening jars.

LEON: It occurs to me that since the curse started with the young Sophia two hundred years ago, perhaps the key to ending it lies with her direct descendant. *(To Sophia)* **(Pg 26-27)** I have every reason to believe that under ordinary circumstances, you have the capability of being an extremely intelligent young woman. But someone has put a cloud over these powers and it is my intention to remove this cloud. I should like to ask you a few very simple questions to know at what point to begin. Now then, what is your favorite color?

SOPHIA: My favorite color. . . is yellow.

LEON: Yellow! Why, Sophia, is your favorite color yellow?

SOPHIA: Because it doesn't stick to your fingers as much.

LEON: That's a very interesting answer, Sophia. There is a certain logic to her response [even though] that logic escapes me completely.

SOPHIA: **(Pg 32)** I know that something happened a long time ago that prevents me from knowing what happened a long time ago. If only you knew me the way I might have been instead of the way I am.

LEON: But if you were not the way you are, then I would not have come here to help you to become the way you might have been. **(Pg 28)** We must begin soon. [Tomorrow.]

SOPHIA: **(Pg 29-30)** I think you are the most beautiful schoolteacher I have ever seen, Master Tolchinsky. I pray that you don't despair of Kulyenchikov and that you will stay with us forever. *(she leaves)*

DR. Z: I think our Sophia has taken a liking to the new schoolmaster.

LEON: If it is true, then standing before you is the happiest man in the universe. Tell me, does she have any suitors?

DR. Z: There is no one. Not even ***him***.

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LEON: ***Him?***

DR. Z: Count Gregor of Kulynechikov. He's one of them. The ones who put the purse on us.

LEON: You mean - a Yousekevitch?

DR. Z: The last of his line. He cares only about avenging his ancestors. If a Zubritsky marries a Yousekevith, they will be satisfied and the nurse will be over.

LEON: **(Pg 36)** Does Sophia love him?

DR. Z: **(Pg 30)** She has said no for many years, but she can't resist much longer. *(thunder clap of doom as Count Gregor who has been listening at the door enters; Leon flustered attempts to make an exit)*

LEON: **(Pg 36)** I don't understand. I'm breaking out in a cold sweat. **(Pg 31)** Tomorrow the education of Sophia Zubritsky begins. Good day.

GREGOR: **(Pg 38-39)** Not ***good*** day. ***One*** day. [It's a part of the curse that] if at the end of one day you have not rais[ed] Sophia's intellect, you must be gone from our village. To remain for even one second past the allotted time means, you will fall victim to the yourself. See you tomorrow. Come, Lenya. (exits with Lenya)

LEON: I cannot believe such nonsense. Threaten me all you want, sir, but I will never leave. To be honest, I love Sophia Zubritsky.

GREGOR: Love?? There is no love in Kulyenchikov. It's all part of the curse. *(He laughs and exits)*

LEON: *(To audience)* But is it true? If I cannot teach Sophia to think in twenty-four hours, she will never be able to love me? I must muster up the strength to break this curse.

(transition - time change)

LEON: *(Leon enters breathless)* **(Pg 46-47)** We cannot lose another moment. The Count said I had only 24 hours to break the curse after I arrived. I arrived yesterday morning at exactly 9 o'clock. It's 8 o'clock now. That means I have only one hour.. Get Sophia!

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DR. Z: Listen! I hear footsteps coming down the stairs.

SOPHIA: *(Sophia enters)* Good morning, Mama. Good morning, Papa. Good morning, schoolmaster.

DR. Z: She got all three right! This is going to be her day, I know it! *(knock – Mishkin enters)*

MISHKIN: **(Pg 52)** I have an important letter for schoolmaster Tolchinsky. It's marked urgent, so I only went to three wrong houses first. *(hands letter to Leon)*

LEON: *(looks at letter then speaks an aside only to the audience)* **(Pg 58)** I am suddenly inspired. I think I have hit upon a plan that will break this curse and save [Sophia] from [Count Gregor]. **(Pg 57)** You can't be cursed unless you ***permit*** yourself to be. Kulyenchikov's lack of intelligence is self-inflicted, caused by guilt and the fear of a tyrannical power. **(Pg 58)** The plan begins! **(Pg 66)** *(back to others)* It's bad news, I'm afraid. My uncle and sole remaining relative has just died, leaving me nothing but all his debts. Before he died, he said he blamed all of his misfortunes on the selfish character of his distant relatives and that even changing his name to Tochinsky never helped him escape destiny's finger.

DR. Z: What was his name before Tochinsky?

LEON: Yousekevitch. Do you realize what this means? **(Pg 52)** [Dr. Zubritsky] – I would like to ask for [Sophia's] hand in marriage.

DR. Z: Yes . . . I'll give my permission right now

LEON: **(Pg 58)** Sophia, you must marry Yousekevitch. I will be Yousekevitch. Will you marry me, Sophia? *(Sophia nods and claps her hands, not really understanding)*

(transition as wedding music plays)

LEON: **(Pg 67)** *(aside to the audience)* [The letter] didn't say that at all. It's a bill from my former college saying I still owe them for last year's tuition. [But] I have planted the bomb in their minds. I now pray God - for the explosion!

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MAGISTRATE: **(Pg 62)** Will the groom step before me? And will the bride step forward? **(Pg 67)** Do you, Leon?

LEON: I do.

MAGISTRATE: And do you, Sophia?

SOPHIA: I do!

MAGISTRATE: If there is anyone here who objects . . . *(silence)* Going once… going twice… going three times… that's it! I now pronounce you ***man and wife***! *(There is a loud thunderclap - everyone but Leon freezes in a trance a couple beats, then relaxes)*

LENYA: **(Pg 68-70)** Nikolai! I - I feel funny - weak in the knees and a dizziness in my head.

DR. Z: It's all right, my dear. Your blood is just pulsating from the excitement. Sometimes that can cause the adrenal glands to oversecrete, resulting in a sudden rush to the head.

LENYA: I never knew you were such a brilliant doctor.

DR. Z: I [just] worry about you because - I love you, my dear.

LENYA: And I love you, Nikolai. Even when I couldn't say it, I knew it in my heart.

LEON: I adore you, Sophia.

SOPHIA: [And] I love you, Leon. It was your faith and courage that won over ignorance.

LEON: No, it was your pure heart and trusting soul that gave me that faith and courage. It was love that destroyed the curse, Sophia, not my puny efforts. *(to audience)* **(Pg 71-72)** When you think of it, it's not such a bizarre story after all. Be honest. Haven't you met someone in your life who came from a place like Kulyenchikov? An aunt, neighbor, your boss? Once the curse was lifted, we became like any other small town or village in any other part of the world. I remained a schoolmaster and dedicated my life to the education of the unenlightened… After all, there are so many Kulyenchikovs in the world.

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
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**With minor adjustments by the 4N6 Fanatics staff to ensure correlation with the original text.*

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